Incident Report: Payment Processing Interruption

Incident ID: INC-0312 Date: March 12, 2026 Severity: SEV-2

Window: 09:23 to approximately 10:18 Status: Resolved

Data classification: Fictional demonstration data

Summary

The payment platform experienced elevated authorization timeouts shortly after a production gateway configuration change. The affected services were checkout-api (new purchases) and renewals-worker (subscription renewals).

Observed evidence

At 09:23, on-call monitoring detected increased gateway authorization timeouts. The authorization failure rate rose from an approximately 3% pre-incident level to a peak of roughly 19% during the incident window.

Recent upstream authorization requests commonly took between 2 and 5 seconds. The deployed gateway timeout had been reduced to 2 seconds at 09:12 (see CHG-0312), making some previously successful requests likely to time out.

Timeline

Time	Event
09:12	Gateway authorization timeout reduced from 8 s to 2 s (CHG-0312).
09:23	Timeout alerts triggered and INC-0312 opened.
09:29	First checkout-support report received.
09:47	Subscription-renewal delays reported.
10:06	Previous 8 s timeout restored.
10:18	Authorization failure rate returned near its baseline.

Assessment and limitations

The leading explanation is that the shorter gateway timeout rejected authorization requests that needed more than two seconds. The timing of the increase and the recovery following rollback support this explanation, but they do not independently prove causality. A more complete investigation would compare request-level traces and upstream-provider measurements.

No estimate of confirmed lost revenue is available in the collected incident material. The support notes document symptoms rather than a complete count of failed transactions.

Next steps

Review timeout values against upstream latency distributions; add a canary stage and rollback threshold for gateway configuration changes; monitor checkout failures and renewal backlog separately.